

THE INTERNATIONAL PORSCHE GARAGE

Porsche 996 Buyer's Checklist — 12 things to check before you buy

- ☐ **1. IMS bearing**
Ask for proof it's been replaced or upgraded. If not, budget \$2,000–\$4,000 — it's the 996's famous weak spot.
- ☐ **2. Rear main seal (RMS)**
Look for oil weeping where engine meets gearbox. Common and cheap-ish to fix, but negotiate on it.
- ☐ **3. Bore scoring**
Blue smoke on cold start or heavy oil use, especially on 3.6 cars. Walk away if it's drinking oil.
- ☐ **4. Coolant pipes**
Early cars have plastic coolant pipes that can let go. Check for coolant smell, stains, or recent replacement.
- ☐ **5. Service history**
Stamps every 12k miles / 2 years minimum. Big services (plugs, belts, fluids) should be documented.
- ☐ **6. Clutch (manuals)**
Heavy pedal or high bite point means it's tired — a \$1,500–\$2,500 job with the RMS done at the same time.
- ☐ **7. Suspension**
20-year-old shocks and bushings are done. Test drive over bumps; knocks and float mean refresh time.
- ☐ **8. Tyres & brakes**
Check tyre date codes and pad depth. A full set of quality rubber plus discs/pads is a big bill.
- ☐ **9. Roof (cabriolets)**
Cycle the roof twice. Watch for slow hydraulics and check the rear window for splits or clouding.
- ☐ **10. Over-rev report**
Get a DME readout from a specialist. Range 4–6 over-revs = money-shift history. Walk away.
- ☐ **11. Pre-purchase inspection**
Always. A Porsche specialist PPI costs a few hundred and has saved buyers thousands. Non-negotiable.
- ☐ **12. Title & accident history**
HPI check (UK) or Carfax (US). Mismatched paint, overspray, or panel gaps tell their own story too.

Buying the car is step one — keeping it alive is the rest. Our 996 workshop manuals cover every job on this list, step by step.

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